

DEPRESSION AMONG COLLEGE STUDENTS IN NEPAL

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Depression Among College Students

Abstract

Depression is a leading cause of disability around the world and contributes greatly to the global burden of disease. It is characterized by persistent sadness and a lack of interest or pleasure in previously rewarding or enjoyable activities. The causes of depression include complex interactions between social, psychological and biological factors. Life events such as childhood adversity, loss and unemployment contribute to and may catalyze the development of depression. The objective of this study is to address the prevalence of depression among college students in Nepal. The information and data used to address the prevalence of depression among college students in Nepal was obtained from previously conducted researches. Further study is needed to be done all over Nepal to address more accurate prevalence of depression among students.

Introduction

Depression is a mental disorder consisting of certain characteristics such as loss of interest, low self-esteem, disturbed appetite and sleep, difficulty in thinking, concentrating or making decisions. It can also lead to a variety of emotional and physical problems and can decrease one's ability to function at work and at home (APA, 2020). As per American Psychiatric Association (APA, 2020), depression symptoms can vary from mild to severe and includes, sadness or having a depressed mood, loss of energy or increased fatigue, thoughts of death and suicide or slowed movements or speech and many more. "People with mild depression have a low mood and other symptoms of depression, but have less intense symptoms. The National Institute of Mental Health (NIMH) state that changes in moods and behavior can indicate mild depression. They may experience feelings of sadness, low energy levels, loss of

Depression Among College Students

appetite and other symptoms. Generally, they can manage these distressing symptoms, but may have a minor effect on their social and work life” (Crawford, 2020). “Moderate depression is the next level up from mild depression. The symptoms are similar to that of mild depression.

Additionally, moderate depression may cause, problems with self-esteem, reduced productivity, feelings of worthlessness, increased sensitivities, excessive worrying. They are severe enough to cause problems at home and work and Severe or major depression is classified as having the similar symptoms as of mild and moderate depression, but are severe and noticeable. It may last for an average of six months or longer. Severe depression requires quick medical treatment and some form of talk therapy” (Cherney, 2018).

The World Health Organization (WHO, 2020) reported that of all illnesses, depression is the leading cause of ill health and disability. They also reported that globally, “more than 264 million people of all ages suffer from depression”. A nationwide cross-sectional study was conducted by Risal et al. (2016, p. 3) on Anxiety and depression in Nepal: prevalence, comorbidity and associations, among a representative sample of Nepalese adults aged 18–65 years. The total sample size was 2100, out of which 861 were males and 1239 females. They found the crude prevalence of depression to be 11.7%.

During college, students experience many things for the first time in their life, including exposure to a new environment and culture, lifestyle, friends, roommates and many more. Also, “they have many social, family and personal expectations and responsibilities to fulfill.” (Riba & Cusumano, 2018). Many students struggle if they can’t manage these new experiences and expectations. And sometimes “when they can’t cope, they can easily show the symptoms of depression and may lead to various health risk behaviors such as, substance abuse, alcoholism, or violence behavior” (Ilgen & Kleinberg, 2011).

Depression Among College Students

This paper tends to address the prevalence of depression among college students in Nepal. The information and data used to address the prevalence of depression among college students in Nepal will be from few researches, articles on this topic

Definition of depression varies from research to research, but the core belief what depression is, is similar in every research. According to a research, “depression is a serious mental disorder associated with substance abuse, risk of mood disorders, alcohol consumption, poor appetite, and suicidal thoughts and can affect family relations, social functioning and academic performances of students” (Bhattarai et al., 2020, p. 2). “There are two main types of depression, major depressive disorder and persistent depressive disorder” (Higuera, 2020). Major depressive disorder also known as clinical depression affects how one feels, think and behave and can lead to a variety of emotional and physical problems. For being diagnosed with clinical depression, one must experience symptoms over a two weeks period. Persistent depressive disorder (PDD) also called dysthymia, is milder but chronic form of depression. Symptoms must last for at least two years for diagnosing PDD.

Common symptoms of depression are: -

- Feelings of helplessness and hopelessness
- Loss of interest in activities once enjoyed
- Sleep disorders
- Loss of energy
- Lack of concentration.

Depression Among College Students

Paudel et al. (2020, p. 29) conducted a cross-sectional study of Depression, Anxiety and Stress among the Undergraduate Students of Pokhara Metropolitan, Nepal. In the study, questionnaire was distributed to the sample of 681 undergraduates from different academic institutions and only 618 approved to take part in this study. On the basis of the findings of this study, the overall prevalence of depression was 38.2%, out of which, 12.8% had mild, 19.1% moderate and 6.3% had severe depression.

Risal, Sanjel, Sharma (2017) conducted a questionnaire based cross-sectional study of depression among the Nursing Students in a University Medical College of Nepal. Among 277 students studying in different years during the academic year (2013-14), 15 students submitted incomplete questionnaire, so the total sample size was 212. The result of the study showed, almost two-fifth of the sampled students were found to have various depressive severity (27.4% mild, 9% moderate, and 1.4% severe). The total prevalence of depression was 37.8%.

Basnet et al. (2013, p. 57) conducted a cross sectional, questionnaire-based study of depression among undergraduate medical students. In the study, 50 students each from Bachelor of Medicine and Bachelor of Surgery (MBBS) first- and third-year students were included. On the basis of the result of this study, it was concluded that the overall prevalence of depression among the students was 29.78%. The prevalence of depression in first- and third- year students was 36.74% and 22.22 % respectively. The prevalence of depression was 32.43% among female students and 28.07% in male students.

Conclusion and Recommendation

Although depression is a serious mental disorder widely prevalent in every society of society, there are very limited number of studies conducted done on its prevalence among

Depression Among College Students

college students in Nepal. Based on the data obtained from very few studies, it can be concluded that the prevalence of depression among college students in Nepal is ranges from 29% to 39%. As most of the researches done are based on the metropolitan cities and a few districts around the capital only, the conclusion may not be accurate. So, this necessitates the need to segregate the students further on the basis of their academic course, family background, economic status and gender. Also, there is a huge gap in the duration of the researches done, which might not help in addressing the accuracy.

So, while the data from previous studies clearly show the prevalence of depression is increasing among college students in Nepal, further study is needed to be done all over Nepal in a proper and fixed durations to address more accurate prevalence of depression among students.

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Depression Among College Students

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